

Vertigo



Photo Lisa approaching the summit of Mt Magellan (3049m) Mt Cook National Park South (photo Simon Bell)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

Section News

May Section Night – 6pm, 12 May 2014

Climbing for free at Hangdog Gym, Petone

Winter is coming - hit the gym and keep the climbing buzz going. Card carrying NZAC members climb for free (or 1 free drink for joint NZAC / Hangdog members) until \$200 tab is gone.

Then we'll hatch plans for a drink and dinner afterwards in Petone.

A small number of spare seats in cars available leaving from Wellington Railway Station at 5:30pm - email wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Snowcraft Course 2014



Planning for the Wellington section snowcraft course is underway. Further information will be available soon - on Facebook, the section website and the couple of Vertigo newsletters.

Provisional information is that the course will have one planning and logistics evening session followed by two weekends based at Tukino on 15-17 August and 29-31 August. The format of the weekends is yet to be decided so keep an eye out for more information about this. Costs for the course are still to be set.

Section Nights are usually at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, 4 Moncrieff Street, Mount Victoria, Wellington on the second Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start 8.00 pm with tea & coffee afterwards

For up to date information about the Wellington Section have a look at [Wellington Section Facebook](#) or [Wellington Section website](#).

BANFF Mountain Film Festival Tour – 2014 – Wellington sessions

Dates: Tuesday 17 (A), Tuesday 24 (B) and Friday 27 (A) June *

Time: 6:30pm

Venue: Paramount Theatre, 25 Courtenay Place, Wellington

Tickets: \$19 NZAC members and students / \$21 non-members

Available from: [Paramount Theatre](#)

*There are two different screening programmes (A) and (B)



Trip Reports

Anyone can play guitar

Simon Bell

Preamble

Ever since I started sport climbing, almost a decade ago, I've heard people talk about the rock routes on Mts Magellan and Drake in the remote Balfour Glacier of Mount Cook National Park. However, it wasn't until last year that I personally talked to someone who had actually been rock climbing in the Balfour! It is a much talked about region but ascents of Magellan and Drake are relatively uncommon.

The 'modern' rock routes in the Balfour were established in the late 80s and 90s. So what's the appeal? Where else in New Zealand can you rock climb 8 or more pitches on trad gear, top out on the summit of a 3000m peak (while leaving your heavy snow-climbing gear at the base of the route), and safely abseil off double-bolt anchors?

A period of settled weather in March arrived and I sent out a last-minute email to try and get a climbing partner to come into the Balfour. I was stoked when Lisa agreed, particularly as I had already had one attempt to get into the Balfour this summer (that trip was aborted due to a poor forecast).

Accessing the Balfour (day 1)

The Balfour glacier is a no-fly zone. Parties climbing the rock routes on Magellan and Drake most commonly access the Balfour from Katies Col. This route is quite favourable in late season conditions (i.e. when the rock routes aren't covered in snow) and is more suited to carrying in large amounts of gear. I hesitate to say access is easy, particularly with a large pack, but navigation is straightforward and it beats climbing over Mt Silberhorn (a 3000m peak!)

We drove to Fox township and the next day (day 1) at 10 am caught a helicopter to the designated landing strip near Big Mac. From here it took about one hour to reach Katies Col and a further four hours to traverse into the Balfour.

The last part of the traverse involves descending a steep and icy snow slope. Fortunately this section is equipped with stainless-steel double-bolt anchors at the top and half-way down. We left a 8.1mm rope hanging at the lower bolts (we flew in with 3 ropes). The decision to leave a rope here was based on a recommendation from someone who I met at Pioneer hut last winter. His party had down-climbed the snow slope. While they were busy rock climbing in the Balfour the 'scrund at the bottom of the slope collapsed. The party had to exit the Balfour via Mt Silberhorn and take the long way around to Katies Col to catch their flight out!

We set-up our tent on a flat part of the Balfour glacier and took a good look at Magellan and Drake. We had come in with some ideas about which route to climb but we soon changed our minds when we saw the mountains up close!



Our camp on the Balfour Glacier. Lisa is uncoiling the aerial of the mountain radio.

Choice of route

Our initial plan was to climb the Balfour Buttress on Magellan. This is the longest route (15 pitches) but also the easiest (crux 15, mostly 10-12). However, while we noted the condition of the bolts we encountered while abseiling into the Balfour was excellent, we couldn't be sure about the quality of the bolts on Magellan. The bolts were placed in 1996 and are on a route called 'Anyone can play guitar'. I hadn't been able to confirm if anyone had actually climbed Magellan since 1996 and used the abseil line.

My concern with climbing Balfour Buttress was that we could get to the summit of Magellan and then find some bolts were deteriorated or had been sheared off with ice movement in winter (I've seen this before on Pudding Rock). We then changed our objective to 'Anyone can play guitar'. The logic being we could inspect the bolted anchors while we climbed the route. As a bonus, if we had enough of the climb we could simply abseil off.

Of course, the main problem with this choice of route was the difficulty. This route is a grade 6-!

Would I be able to climb the 'punch in the guts' first pitch? (a 45m crack which approaches vertical for the last 15 meters, a sustained grade 19). Probably not I thought, but at least the gear is good!



Mt Magellan (3049m, left) and Drake (2960m, right) from the Balfour glacier. The 8-pitch route we climbed 'Anyone can play guitar' is marked in green.

The 35 hour guitar lesson (days 2 and 3)

Day 2 probably didn't start as early as it should have. We convinced ourselves that as it wouldn't take long to access the base of the route (we allowed only 1 hour), and that since it would take a few hours after daylight for the sun to touch (and dry) the rock, we didn't need to get-up too early. Actually, we were simply tired from the walk in and from our everyday lives and didn't want to get up too early!

Although March is pretty late-season, we had met some guides at Fox who were about to take clients up Lendenfeld Peak, the sort of climb that is normally done in November / December. Snow conditions were great in general, but we still managed to reach a couple of dead-ends (wide crevasses) and getting to the base of the route was somewhat challenging and time consuming.

We found a bolt at the start of the route and it was in excellent condition. This was very reassuring (there was some evidence that it had been hit by stones, but it was only slightly chipped). By the time we had stashed our snow-climbing gear and actually started to climb it was 1pm!

We each climbed with a bag. I had a small running bag (15L) with a down jacket and some food and water. Lisa had a bigger bag but it was mostly empty. In addition to what I had she carried the PLB and Jetboil stove. Half-way up the route there was a snow patch which would provide us with plenty of water from our stove and single gas canister.

I stared up at pitch one. It looked every bit as difficult as I had imagined. I normally avoid crack climbing or just try and climb them via a lay-back. This almost works on a 10m crack, but not so well on a 45m one! Of course we didn't tape our hands up (or even have spare tape available) so I just did my best to keep my skin.



Looking up at the 50m 'punch in the guts' pitch 1 (crux 19).

I think it is fair to say this is the hardest pitch I've ever climbed in the mountains. When I say pitch, I mean 3. That's right, once I ran out of gear at 25m I simply built an anchor and bought up Lisa. I repeated this again before finally completing 'pitch 1' and finding the first bolt anchor.

On this climb I had 13 cams and managed to use about 10. On a 50m pitch that would give about a 5m spacing between gear. I'm happy with that on climbs where I'm very unlikely to fall but not when I'm climbing at my limit (and beyond). After several hours, many rests, quite a bit of pulling on cams, some loss of skin and one lead fall (just as I was topping out), we finally arrived at the top of pitch one! If only I had taken guitar lessons!

By this stage I was fairly sure that there was no way we would reach the summit before dark. However, we both ignored this fact, finished the last of our water in the hot afternoon sun and continued on with the climb.

Pitch 1 had left me shattered but I carried on leading the remainder of the pitches to the summit. Pitch 2 (16) was really enjoyable, although the fatigue from pitch 1 made it

challenging. The last part involved climbing a massive semi-detached block (about 10m high). The block was very solid, but don't be below it in a major earthquake! Interestingly, the Shogun route on Drake now has a new start as the bottom 20m or so of the buttress has fallen off.



Lisa on Pitch 2 (16), climbing the massive semi-detached block (great trad anchor on top, bolted anchor a little higher up)

Pitch 3 (15) and 4 (14) were quite easy but I managed to mess up the route finding a bit and had to down-climb almost half of pitch 3. It was starting to get dark by the time we started pitch 4. We were hoping to find the snowy slabby area soon and kept an eye out for a good bivy ledge. Towards the end of the pitch we found an 'acceptable' rock ledge which was a few steps away from snow (our source of water and warmth). We put in an anchor and got ready for a night of star-watching!



Forced bivy at 2600m near the top of pitch 4. Everything was secured to the anchor.

This is the second open bivy that Lisa and I have shared (the first being on Malte Brun). I simply won't do the kind of route where an open bivy is a possibility without an excellent forecast. In this case, we could have descended in the dark and got back to our tent. But that would have spelt the end of our climbing trip. Neither of us would have been keen to get-up the next day and repeat pitch 1! Fixing a rope was an option but it seemed easier to spend the night on route.

The evening started with an amazing sunset over the west coast. Cloud covered the ocean but over land the sky was cloudless. This was followed by several hot drinks to rehydrate and warm us. A moon accompanied us for the first half of the night and psychologically made us warmer. Speaking of warmth, there wasn't much. The down jackets were great but we had no shoes except our rock shoes. Lisa had the large (30L) bag and used this for warmth. I had to make do with some dry thick socks and my climbing pants (no long-johns). There was no wind overnight.

Every hour or so we would boil water and put it in our Nalgines. These make excellent hot water bottles and once the water has cooled down a bit, drinking it provides further warmth.

As the moon descended over the horizon so did our spirits. Sleeping for more than a few minutes at a time wasn't possible due to the cold and the fact that, whenever I fell asleep, I'd lean over from my sitting position, which would wake me up. Everything was secured to the anchor so we couldn't actually fall off our ledge but we could slide down it a bit which was quite uncomfortable.

We got going shortly after light on day 3. The sun wouldn't be on the rock for hours but we were eager to get moving and warm again. The remaining 4 pitches to the summit were quite straightforward (13, 15, 13, 8) and we made good progress to the summit.

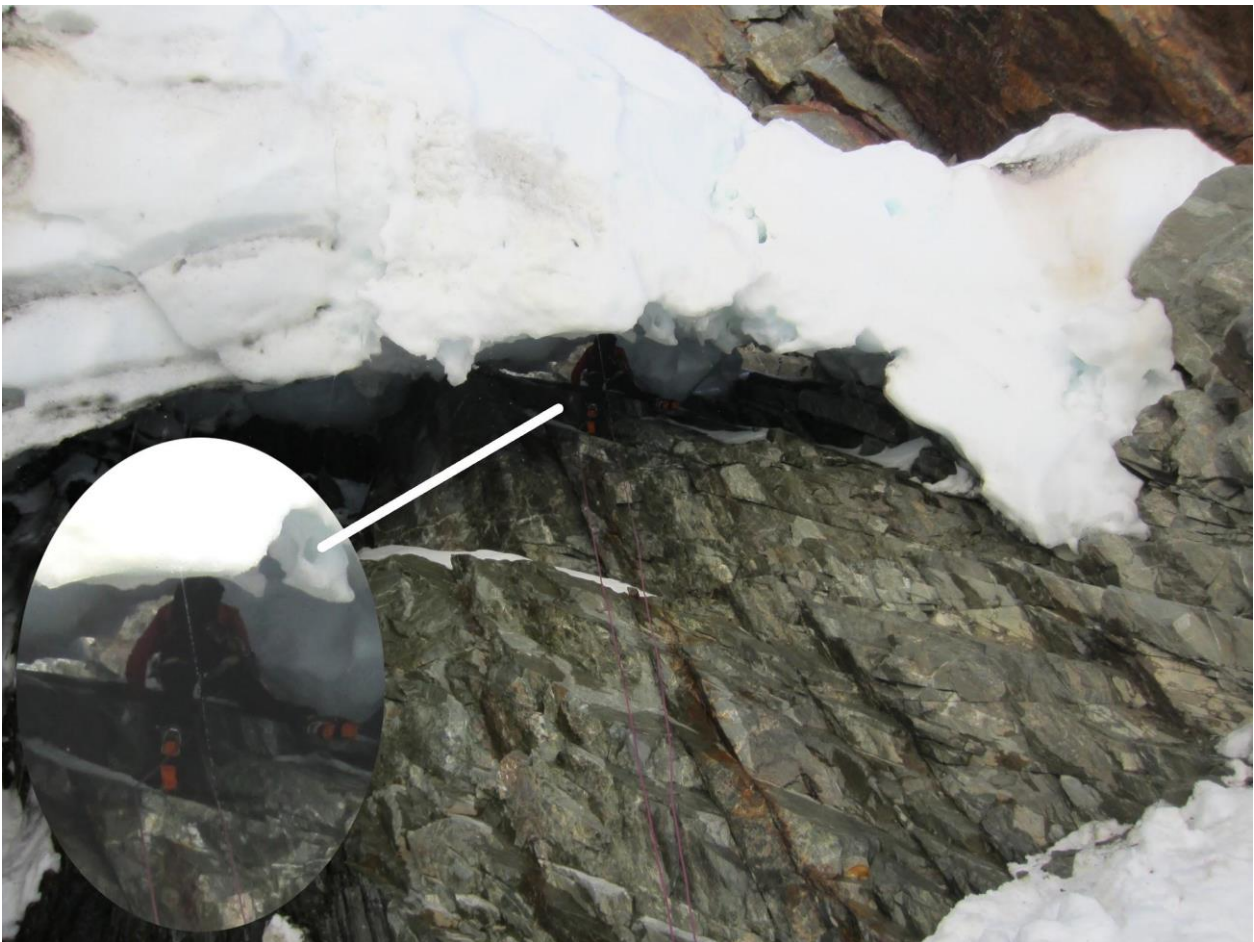


Lisa approaching the summit of Mt Magellan. Big Mac (left) and Torres (right) in the background with the access route from Katies Col mostly visible.

We summited at 11:30am and soaked up the excellent views. I scoped out Mt Torres, the Balfour face of Mt Tasman and the North face of Mt Hicks as possible future climbs while we enjoyed another drink and the remains of yesterday's lunch.

The abseil descent was relatively smooth, although I had managed to drop my belay device on the ascent (a habit of mine) so I had to abseil on a double Munter hitch. The resulting rope twist may have contributed to us getting the rope stuck once. Getting this free required me to ascend some of pitch 2 again which was quite unappealing, particularly in our tired states.

Once off the rock pitches we still had quite a bit of work to get back to our tent. The afternoon snow was very soft and we did some further abseils off rock bands where possible. Our last major obstacle was a 'schrund type feature near a rock band. We had sidled this on ascent but abseiling this way would be problematic. Fortunately we found a novel solution, which was to abseil through a narrow gap between the rock and the snow.



Lisa abseiling in the gap between the rock and the snow

We finally arrived back at our tent at 7pm. It was great to finally be back and have a proper meal and a good night's sleep. We promptly abandoned any plans for climbing Drake the following day and our thoughts turned to home.

Aftermath (days 4 and 5)

Day 4 saw us depart the Balfour around 9:30am. Three hours later we were at Katies Col and set-up the mountain radio to ask for a ride out. Unfortunately, the cloud had already come in from the sea and covered Fox township, making flying impossible. Helicopters were flying earlier in the day and we wished we had gotten up earlier. We descended to the landing strip and set-up camp once again. The remainder of the afternoon was spent eating, drinking and enjoying the excellent weather and views. Actually, it was pretty neat to spend one more day in the hills before returning to civilisation!

On day 5 we were picked up at 8am and returned to Fox for a much deserved shower and hot breakfast. Later that day, in Christchurch, we met Peter Dickson (who put up many of the routes in the 80s and 90s) and told him about the climb we had done. We managed to do about the only climb on Drake and Magellan that he hadn't done!

I really enjoyed our trip into the Balfour. Despite the first pitch of our chosen route being a bit too hard for us, we managed to tick the peak off and, more importantly, have a great adventure on the way. I'll be back for Drake. In the mean-time, I'd better take up guitar lessons (aka crack climbing!)

Notices

Press Release - Nepal Mountaineering Assoc re Everest Avalanche 18 April 2014

Dear all,

Thank you very much for your concern over the avalanche occurred on Everest on 18 April 2014 at 5800 m of Everest. We also would like to mention that all of your condolence messages have conveyed to all the bereaved families and we are very grateful for all of your serious concern. We are receiving so many numbers of enquiries from all the around the world and we are in the process of creating the cordial environment for the expeditions to run. We would like share to some vital information about the current situation.

Abandon of expedition

I would like confirm that we have not received any confirmation regarding the abandon of the expeditions on Everest. Whatever the news disseminated in the media about the abandon of the expedition is false and does not any hold any sense. Yes, Nepalese mountaineers are in deep sorrow after the huge human loss and they are trying to cope with the situation. They are trying to be mentally prepared for the expedition and it will take some time to return in the normal situation.

Demands of climbers

I also would like to confirm that support climbers have forwarded some demands concerned with insurance, remuneration, future of the children of dead and missing climbers, injured climbers etc. The demands had already been addressed by Government of Nepal. Please visit the following links for the press statement:

<http://nepalmountaineering.org/newspage-129-Press%20statement%20released%20by%20Ministry%20of%20Culture,%20Tourism%20and%20Civil%20Aviation-%2022%20April>

<http://nepalmountaineering.org/newspage-128-Minute%20of%20Emergency%20Joint%20Meeting>

High official visit to Everest BC

Government of Nepal has decided to dispatch high officials for the visit with Nepalese climbers, high altitude workers, sardar staying at BC to circulate the message about the recent decision. The delegation team will have the representatives of Nepal Mountaineering Association (NMA), Trekking Agencies Association of Nepal (TAAN), Nepal National Mountain Guide Association (NNMGA) and Expedition Operators' Association of Nepal (EOAN), Sagarmatha Pollution Control Committee (SPCC).

Welfare Program

We are receiving numbers of emails with the interest to support the families of deceased and missing mountaineers. Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation has already decided to give responsibility NMA to formulate welfare program for the children and families. We will finalize the terms of condition for the operation of fund received from different alpine clubs, climbers, well-wishers, associations. All the details of this procedure will be forwarded once we come into conclusion.

Our request

We are very sorry for not responding your mails on time since we are very much engaged in conducting rescue operation and safe handing over of the dead climbers to their families. After that, we had to be involved in funeral procession for the deceased climbers, which was organized on 21 April 2014. Presently, we are in series of discussion with government officials, international expedition leaders, Nepalese climbers, high altitude workers, sardar to settle down the issue and resume the expedition. I also would like to circulate the information and news on the basis of fact and supportive documents.

Mountaineering tourism is very important for us and it is the backbone of our tourism industries. Mountain tourism plays a special role in the income generation and employment opportunity for most of the people living in the Himalayan region, hence, the failure of mountain tourism means the failure of whole tourism economy. We are trying our best to save this industry and we need support from all of you on this matter. Therefore, on behalf of NMA, I would like to request all of you to consider our situation and help us to save this industry.

Thanks and regards

Ang Tshering Sherpa

President

Nepal Mountaineering Association

P O Box 1435, Nagpokhari, Naxal, Kathmandu

Phone: 977-1-4434525 / 4435442

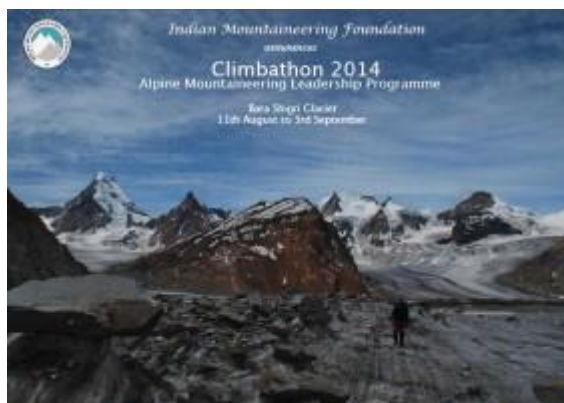
Fax: 977-1-4434578

W: www.nepalmountaineering.org

E: office@nepalmountaineering.org / peaks@nma.wlink.com.np

Skype: nepmountain

Indian Mountaineering Foundation - Climbathon 2014



The Indian Mountaineering Foundation (IMF), being the apex body for mountaineering in India, has the objective of organising, supporting and providing a base for expeditions for mountaineering, skiing, rock climbing, trekking at high altitude and to promote, encourage, support and execute schemes for related adventure activities and environmental protection work in the Himalaya.

The IMF will be conducting an Alpine mountaineering leadership programme-“Climbathon 2014” at Bara Shigri Glacier of Lahaul & Spiti in H.P. from 11th August 2014 to 03 September 2014. The objective of the programme is to disseminate the latest techniques of alpine

mountaineering and develop alpine mountaineering skills. Application form and details of climbathon -2014 are available on IMF website:-www.indmount.org

IMF is looking forward to participation of international climbers as participants/ instructors in the programme. You are requested to give wide publicity to this event and forward names of volunteer club members.

Charges for the said camp will be US\$ 500 per participant.

You are requested to send confirmation at the earliest please.

Yours faithfully,

S K Kutty
Wg Cdr
Honorary Secretary

New benefit for members – Craig Potton Publishing

As new publications are released, specific titles will be made available to NZAC members at a 20% discount. The current offer and time limit to redeem the offer are detailed below.

Information on the books' content may be found in the attached PDFs:

Current Applicable titles:

- New Zealand Whitewater ISBN 9780473260941 RRP \$34.99
- Above the Treeline ISBN 9781877517761 RRP \$49.99

Discount and discount code:-

- 20% off RRP by quoting Discount Code (obtained from [Margaret](#), or [Narina](#))
- Free Freight within New Zealand

Dates available:

- 1st March 2014 until 30th June 2014

Link to the Craig Potton Publishing website:-

- <http://www.craigpotton.co.nz/>

Arapiles Pocket Companion

New to stock - Arapiles Pocket Companion. A handy down-sized version of the Arapiles Selected Climbs. Both the pocket companion and the full-size version are available online from NZAC: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/shop/31?category=31>

American Alpine Club Seeks Climbers to join the 2014 International Climbers' Meet

Date: 2014-10-06 (All day) - 2014-10-11 (All day)

Location: Yosemite Valley, USA

Organiser: American Alpine Club



The American Alpine Club is having another International Climbers meet this fall in Yosemite. Below is the information. For more information we also have a Facebook page

<http://www.facebook.com/InternationalClimbersMeet2012?ref=hl>

and a website <https://www.americanalpineclub.org/p/internationalclimbersmeet>

AAC would love to have attendance from the NZAC.

The American Alpine Club is hosting its 7th annual International Climbers' Meet (ICM) and we would like to extend an invitation to all of NZAC members to participate in this annual event to be held the week of October 6 - October 11, 2014 in Yosemite Valley. Experience with placement and removal of protection, multi-pitch rope management, at least two years of technical rock climbing, and the ability to follow sustained 5-8 granite is mandatory. The goal is to host a diverse group of climbing abilities from a multitude of countries. American Alpine Club members from the USA will be participating again this year.

The fee is \$415 USD per person. Participants provide their own transportation to Yosemite Valley, California.

Your fee includes:

- Car pooling opportunities and transportation information for travel to Yosemite*
- Seven nights and six days of camping at secluded Yellow Pines camp ground
- Three catered meals per day
- Five days of climbing in spectacular Yosemite Valley
- One day of a stewardship project for Yosemite Valley National Park
- Nightly campfire for storytelling, socializing, and general carousing
- Partner with other participants or experienced host climbers

Last year's meet was an amazing adventure. Yosemite Park closed one week before the meet started. Although there was some disappointment that we could not go to Yosemite, 50 participants travelled to the Eastern Sierras where we climbed, camped, watched movies on the

side of a van, and bonded over the fact that no matter what happens, climbers will still climb. Although we do not anticipate another closure of Yosemite Valley, the show will go on no matter the circumstances. We hope your members will come join the fun in the premier American climbing area of Yosemite Valley.

*Due to the rising costs of liabilities associated with providing transportation to and from Yosemite we regret that we can no longer provide this service. We will have a central communication site where participants can plan carpooling, bus rides, and other forms of shared transport. Once in Yosemite, there is a bus system that services the Valley. There will also be numerous participants with autos, so we don't anticipate any issues with transport.

Deadline for applications is June 16.

Submit attached application electronically via e-mail to icm@americanalpineclub.org

Questions? Contact: icm@americanalpineclub.org

For more information go to: <http://www.americanalpineclub.org/p/internationalclimbersmeet>

Carol Kotchek, ICM organizer, The American Alpine Club

Remarkables Ice and Mixed festival 14 – 17 August 2014

SO WHATS THIS FESTIVAL ALL ABOUT?

- Bringing together a huge cross section of climbers from around NZ and the world.
- Beginners get to rub shoulders and share the rope with the top winter alpine climbers in NZ.
- Clinics, competitions, races and social gatherings advance and promote modern mixed climbing.
- Showcasing the new and existing route potential on NZ's most accessible multi pitch winter training area The Remarkables.
- Sharing local knowledge and forming new climbing partnerships.
- Fundraising for the NZAC expedition fund.

There are limited places available on the clinics and discounts available for NZAC members so be quick to secure your place. Full details on the festival can be found at

<http://www.iceandmixedfestival.co.nz/#>

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New Zealand Alpine Club

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Expedition Capital Fund – supporters thank you

Thank you to our three corporate supporters of the NZAC Expedition Capital Fund for their donations to date.



We encourage members to continue supporting these companies to help us grow this fund for the Expeditions of the future.

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/donation/expedition-capital-fund>

Wellington Section 2012/13 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Email alias*	Contact
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	027 768-2185
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Julian Davidson	secretary or CM2	
Treasurer	Adam Newberry	treasurer	
National Rep	Dan Pringle		
Patron	John Nankervis		
Trips	Vacant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	John Yu		
	Sharran Came		
Other Roles:			
Gear	vacant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	vacant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	vacant		
Instruction - AIC	vacant		
Instruction - Rock	vacant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Carolyn Ellis		Kaz1963@gmail.com
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Yu	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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Creating happiness through
better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



**HangDog Rock Climbing
Adventures**

453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181
info@hangdog.co.nz

www.hangdog.co.nz

i climb
.co.nz

Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer



Ocelot
\$115



MXC 820
\$230



Makalu
\$255



Caiman
\$230

all crampons include anti-balling plates
and crampon bag



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If undelivered please return to:

NZAC Wellington Section
PO Box 1628
Wellington

